



Shaving equipment

Soldiers usually carried a straight razor and soap, although few would have had a shaving kit as elegant as this. Army rules, often ignored, prescribed a face wash every day and a full bath once a week.

Reasons for fighting

The motivation of Union troops was mixed. Patriotism drove many into the ranks, outraged at the rebel threat to the integrity of the United States. An idealistic opposition to slavery was far less common. Abolitionism was supported in some Massachusetts regiments, but on the whole Union troops were indifferent to emancipation; some were even opposed to it.

The simple desire for adventure and the experience of war attracted many young men to enlist, but material considerations